THE AGE OF NELSON



Glorious First of June
The French flagship *Montagne* (right) and the British flagship *Queen Charlotte* (left) are locked in a fierce gunnery duel. The battle, fought far out in the Atlantic in 1794, ended in a notable British victory. A British boat is shown picking up survivors from French ships.

THE FIGURE OF HORATIO NELSON, Britain's greatest admiral, dominates the period of the French Revolutionary and Napoleonic Wars. Nelson embodied the principles that had been instilled into the Royal Navy by its best admirals over previous generations: attack at all costs, seizing the initiative, and pursuing decisive victory. But he carried these principles to unsurpassed extremes. Building on the new tactics pioneered by Admiral Sir George Rodney at Les Saintes in 1782, Nelson set out to break the enemy line and create a "pell-mell" battle in which superior gunnery would carry the day and the enemy would be as far as possible annihilated. His two greatest victories, at the Nile and Trafalgar—the battle in which he died—not only contributed to the eventual defeat of France but ensured British domination of the world's oceans for the rest of the 19th century.

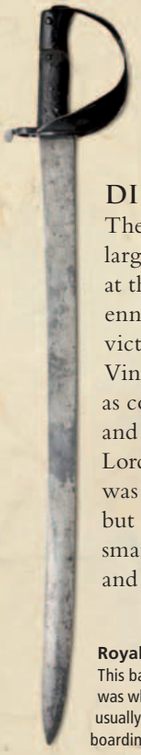
Britain's greatest national hero
Horatio Nelson's personal bravery and bold, innovative tactics had already made a him a legend in his lifetime. Death in his hour of victory at Trafalgar ensured the legend would never become tarnished.



NAVIES UNDER STRAIN

Between 1793 and 1815 Britain's Royal Navy was almost continuously at war, fighting not only the French but, at various times, the Spanish, Dutch, Danes, and Americans as well. The triumph of British sea power in this long period of conflict was in no sense predictable or easily gained. The Royal Navy frequently fought against numerically equal or superior enemy forces. If the British were widely recognized as best at gunnery, the French generally had better ships, and the Spanish bigger ones.

The British were greatly aided by the impact of the French Revolution of 1789 upon their most dangerous opponent. The French navy never fully recovered from the chaos of the revolutionary period, when mutinies were commonplace and many experienced naval commanders were lost, either fleeing into exile or persecuted as counter-revolutionaries. Yet the British navy was also operating under great strain. The authorities' fear of revolution made issues of discipline on board ship acute. Simmering discontent spilled over into large-scale fleet mutinies at Spithead and the Nore in 1797. The lack of shore leave—denied for fear of desertion—the unfair allocation of prize money, poor food and pay, and excessive punishments were the mutineers' main grievances. To the relief of the British government the mutinies were suppressed through punishment and concessions, and never recurred on a similar scale. Yet the sheer extent and duration of the conflict threatened traditional systems of recruitment and discipline. Britain's policy of permanent blockade of French ports meant sailors remained at sea for unprecedented periods of time. The pressing of men into service, usually a workable system of conscription, became oppressive because of the massive demand for crew. Too many landsmen, including convicts, were recruited.



Royal Navy cutlass
This basic, utilitarian sword was what the British sailor usually had to rely on when boarding an enemy ship.

DISCIPLINE AND INITIATIVE

The Royal Navy overcame its problems, largely through finding the right leadership at the right time. Admiral Sir John Jervis—ennobled as Earl St. Vincent after his victory over the Spanish at Cape St Vincent in 1797—was a major influence as commander of the Mediterranean and Channel fleets, then First Lord of the Admiralty. Jervis was a severe disciplinarian, but his insistence on smartness, cleanliness, and daily gunnery

